

The Curious Kid Meets Lao Tzu

A Curious Kid Adventure — Book 3



by Evan Paliotta

IRONWOOD BOOKS

The Curious Kid Meets Lao Tzu

Book 3

by Evan Paliotta

IRONWOOD BOOKS

The Curious Kid Meets Lao Tzu

A Curious Kid Adventure — Book 3

Text © 2026 Evan Paliotta

Illustrations generated with AI assistance

Published by Ironwood Books

A division of MVP Ventures LLC

Jacksonville Beach, FL

All rights reserved. No part of this book may be
reproduced without written permission from the publisher.

Illustrations in this book were created with the assistance
of artificial intelligence.

First edition, 2026

ISBN: 979-8-177167053

ironwoodbooks.com

The Curious Kid woke in the warm, quiet night.

There by his pillow lay an interesting sight,
a book made of green bamboo, tied with a string,
with carved out letters spelling Tao Te Ching.



He touched the green book, and his world was released
that swung the whole farm and sent him straight east.



He whirled and he swirled and the long night was spun,
till he landed down softly, and the wild ride was done.

He stood in a grove, in a hush soft and still,
where the tall bamboo swayed on the slope of a hill.
A silver stream slid by him, quiet and low,
and carried on down, soft and steady and slow.



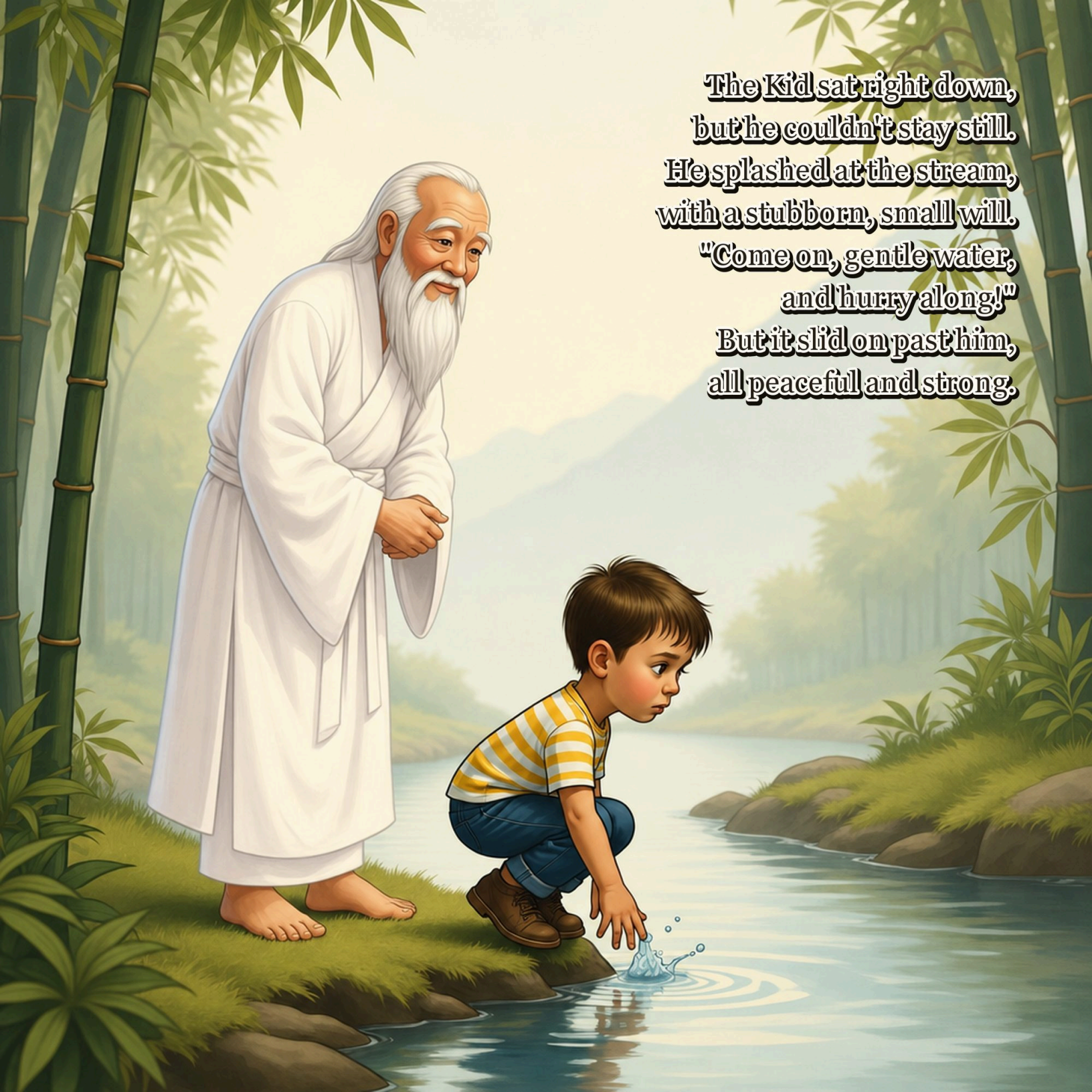


Then up by the stream
sat an old man in white,
as still as the bamboo,
as soft as the light.

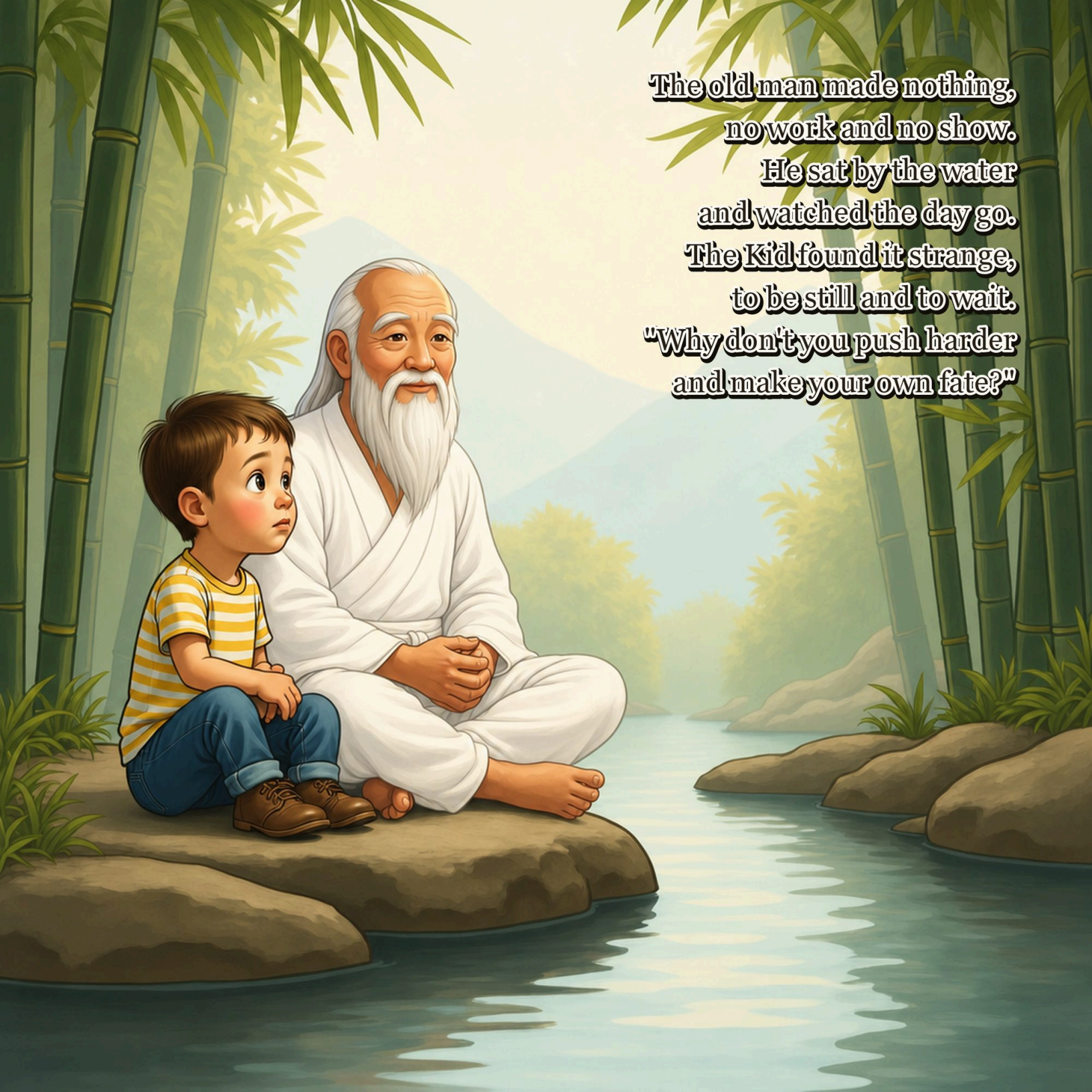
"Welcome, young one," said the sage.

"Rest with me
by the hush of this water,
and watch what you see."

The Kid sat right down,
but he couldn't stay still.
He splashed at the stream,
with a stubborn, small will.
"Come on, gentle water,
and hurry along!"
But it slid on past him,
all peaceful and strong.



The old man made nothing,
no work and no show.
He sat by the water
and watched the day go.
The Kid found it strange,
to be still and to wait.
"Why don't you push harder
and make your own fate?"



"You will see, if you watch," said the sage, calm and low.
The sun slipped away, the stars started to glow.

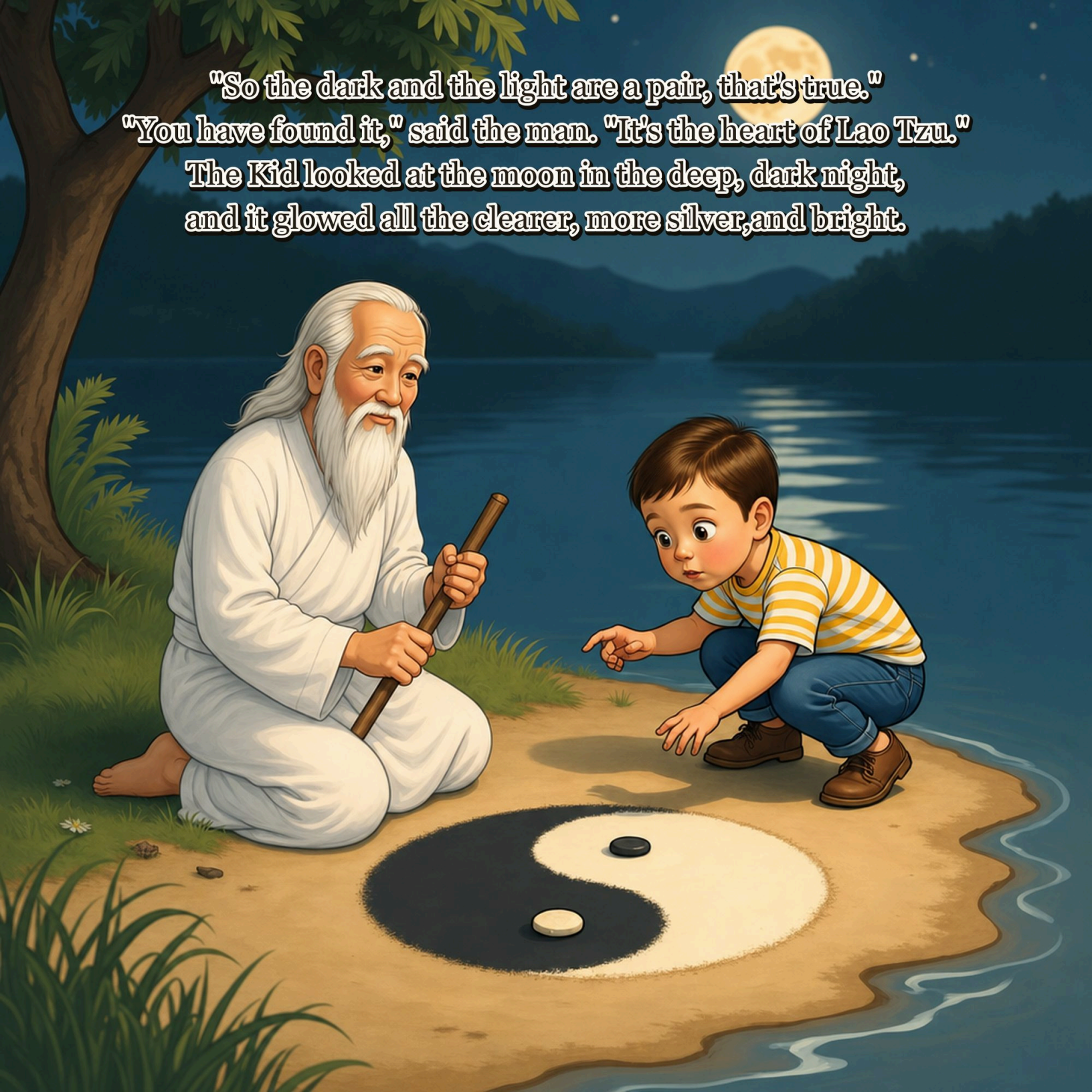


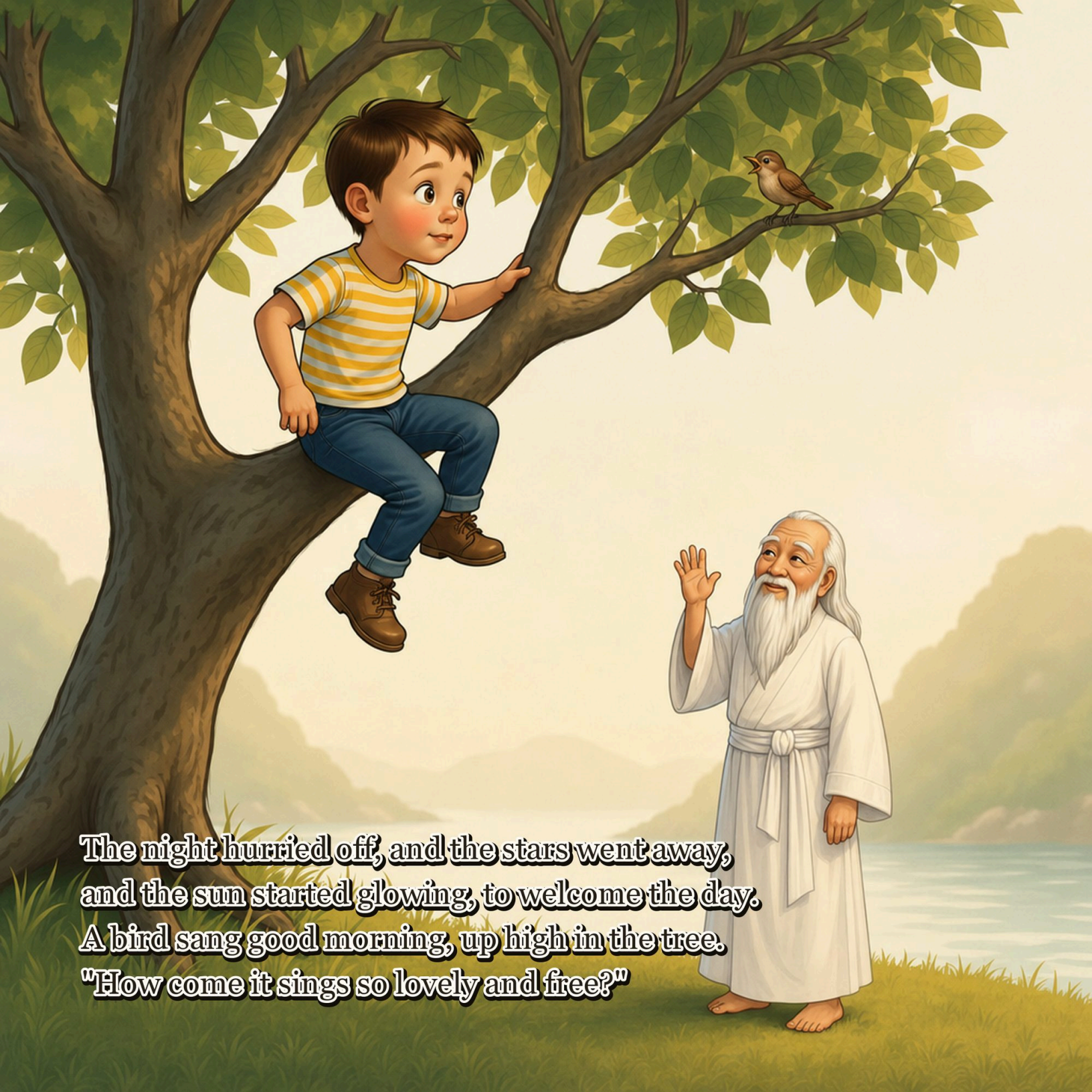
The Kid looked at the moon and he asked with a pout,
"Who turns on the moon's shine when the daylight is out?"



"The moon needs the dark
all around
to show off its silver
and light the whole ground.
The dark isn't empty,
it isn't a fright,
it's the stage that lets all of
the pale moon shine bright.

"So the dark and the light are a pair, that's true."
"You have found it," said the man. "It's the heart of Lao Tzu."
The Kid looked at the moon in the deep, dark night,
and it glowed all the clearer, more silver, and bright.





The night hurried off, and the stars went away,
and the sun started glowing, to welcome the day.
A bird sang good morning, up high in the tree.
"How come it sings so lovely and free?"

Then the bird stopped at the end of its song,
and the sage said, "Hush, and listen along."

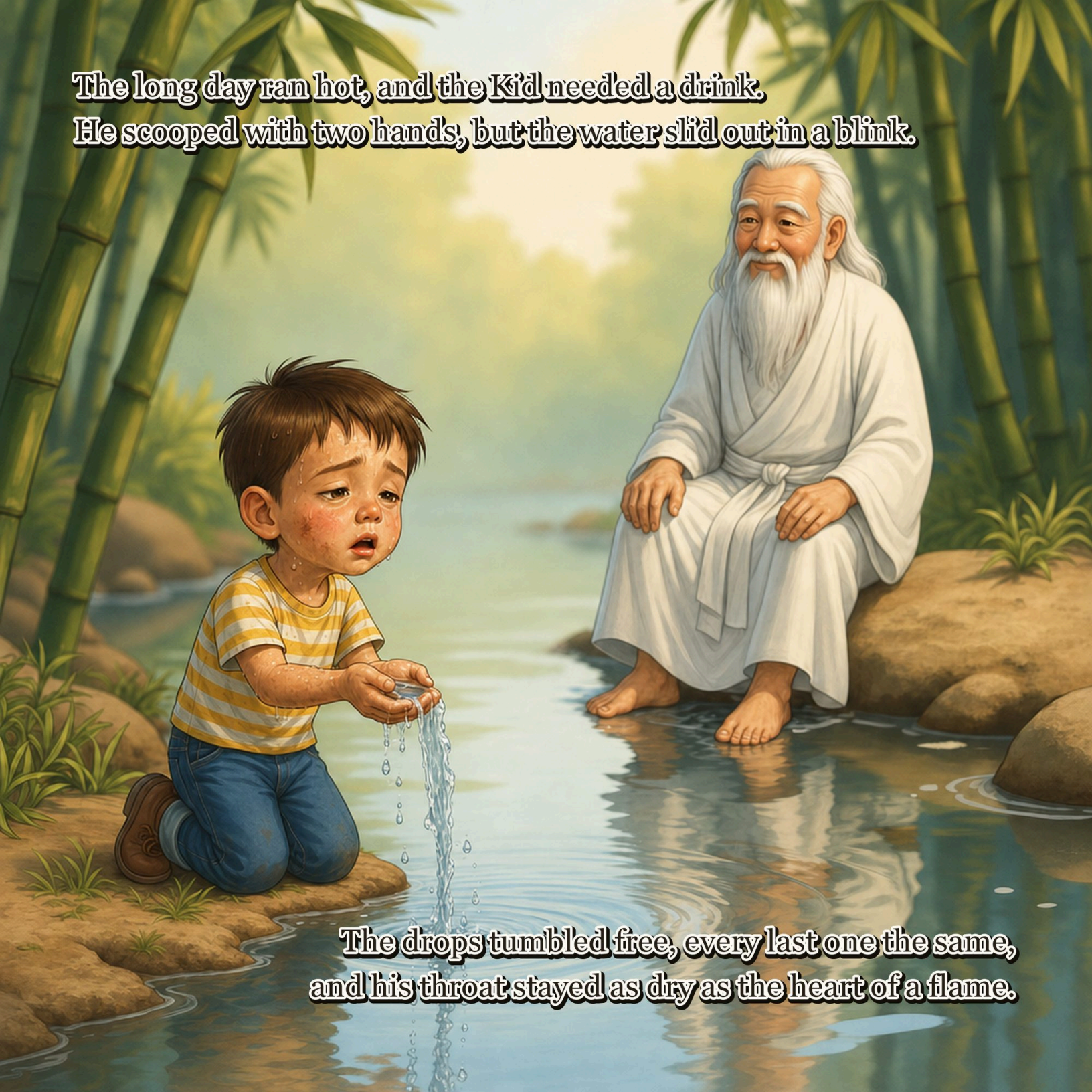


It's the quiet between every note that they hold,
the hush that gives each little bird-song its gold."

The Kid jumped up with his arms to the clouds,
"To make great music you need quiet and loud!"
Then he laughed at himself with a dried, thirsty sigh,
and went for a cool drink from the stream running by.



The long day ran hot, and the Kid needed a drink.
He scooped with two hands, but the water slid out in a blink.



The drops tumbled free, every last one the same,
and his throat stayed as dry as the heart of a flame.

Then Lao Tzu reached out and he lifted a cup,
a hollow of green bamboo, and held it up.



The Kid filled it and drank, and he saw with a grin:
the empty inside was the part holding it in.

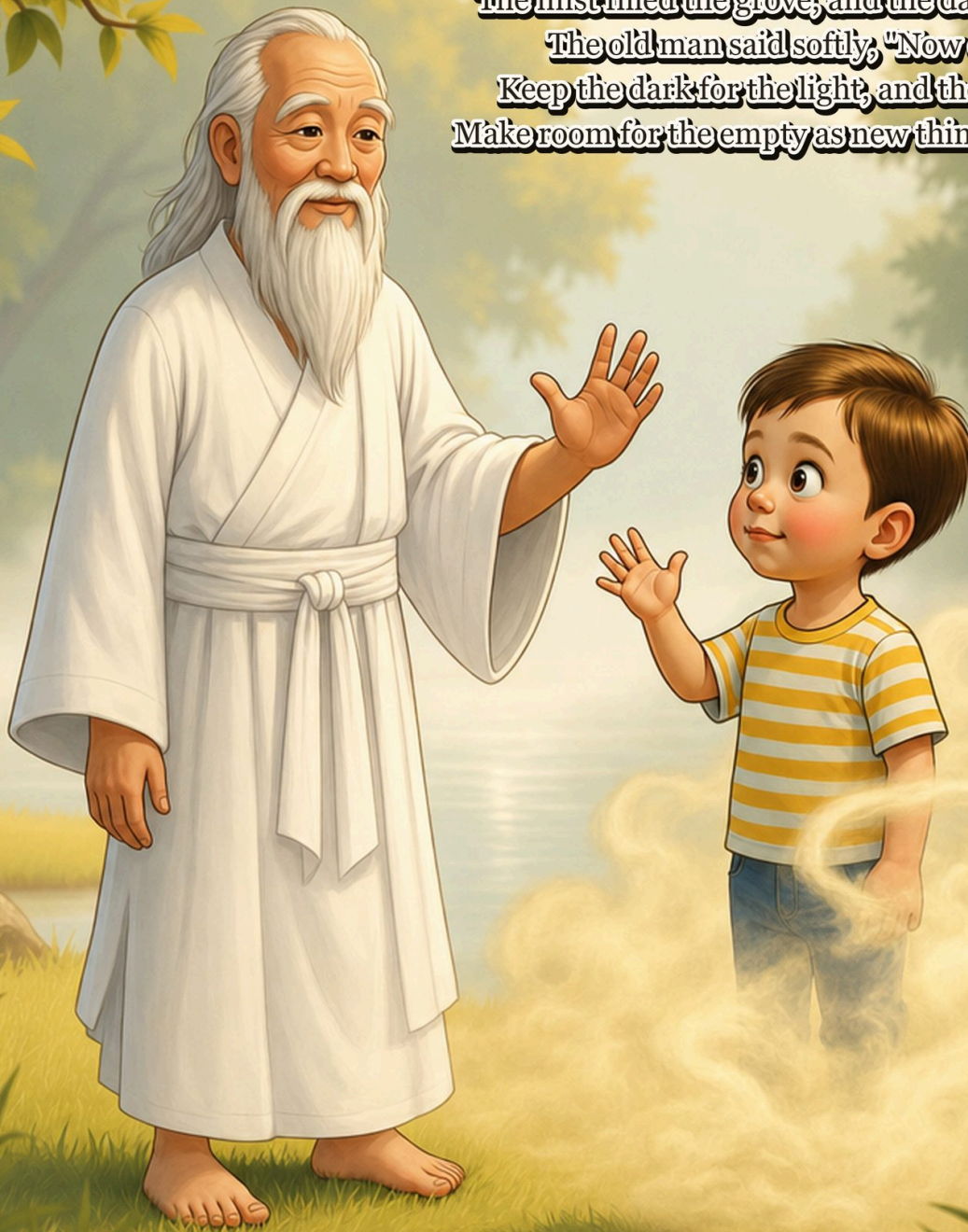


The Kid looked at the cup,
near empty and free,
and he grinned at the space
that let the water be.

**"Now you have it," said the sage. "And you can see,
each little wonder leans on its opposite to be."**



The mist filled the grove, and the day slipped on by.
The old man said softly, "Now comes goodbye.
Keep the dark for the light, and the quiet for song.
Make room for the empty as new things come along."





The book gave a tug, and the night slipped away.
He woke in his field, on his bed, where he lay.
And the moon, round and full, sat up high in the sky,
and he felt safe and warm, though he didn't know why.

A young child with brown hair, wearing a yellow and white striped shirt and blue jeans, stands with their back to the viewer on a light-colored path. The path is flanked by tall, dark grass and leads straight towards a large, bright full moon in a dark, starry night sky. The child's arms are slightly out to the sides. The scene is peaceful and contemplative.

"If the whole night went dark,"
the Kid said with a grin,
"there'd be no place
for the light to shine in."

He looked at the moon
in the deep, endless dark,
and he knew the dark held up
the warm, silver spark.

The Kid looked about and he saw it, at last.
The day needs the night and the future needs the past.
The song needs the quiet, and the black needs the white.
And the good needs the bad, every day and each night.





The dark gives the light, and the quiet gives song.
The empty gives room, and so opposites belong.

Stay curious.

IRONWOOD BOOKS • ironwoodbooks.com